

Theories of Adult Learning

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Agenda

- Andragogy
- Other models for adult learning
- Summary

Andragogy

- The art and science of helping adults learn.
- The focus is on empowering adult learners by considering their unique life situations and experiences..

Andragogy: Model of Assumptions

1. **[Self-directing]** As a person matures, their self-concept moves from being dependent toward being self-directing.
2. **[Experience]** An adult accumulates a growing reservoir of experience, which is a rich resource for learning.
3. **[Readiness to learn]** An adult's readiness to learn is closely tied to the developmental tasks of their social role.
4. **[Problem-centered]** As people mature, they seek immediacy of knowledge to an application, so adults are more problem-centered than subject-centered.
5. **[Motivation]** Adults are motivated to learn by internal factors, not external ones.

Models for Adult Learning

- Cross's CAL model (1981)
- McCluskey's Theory of Margin
- Knox's Proficiency Theory
- Jarvis's Learning Process

CAL (Characteristics of Adults as Learners) Model

Personal Characteristics

- >Physiological/Aging----->
- >Socialculture/Life phases----->
- >Physiological/Developmental stages----->

Situational Characteristics

Part-time learning versus full-time learning
Voluntary learning versus compulsory learning

Source: Cross, 1981, p. 235

Problems with CAL Model

- Variables may be too broadly defined
- Focused on characteristics of adults
- Tells us little about how adults learn or if they learn differently than children do
- Personal characteristics could apply to children since they are on continua
- Situational characteristics do not distinguish adults from children
- Some adults are full-time, and some participate because of mandatory requirements
- Some pre-adults are part-time learners, and some learning is voluntary

McCluskey's Theory of Margin

$$M = L/P$$

- M $\Rightarrow$ margin left for learning
- Load $\Rightarrow$ load of life
- Power $\Rightarrow$ power of life

Outcome: The more margin one has, the greater the chance of dealing with sources of load. The less margin one has, the lower the chance of dealing with sources of load.

Factors of Mcluskey's Theory of Margin

Load Factors:

- External: normal life tasks - family (tasks of life such as family), work (career), community (socio-economic status)
- Internal: life expectancies developed by people – aspirations (self-concept), desires (goals), future expectations (personal expectations)

Power Factors:

- External resources like family support, social abilities, and economic abilities
- Internally acquired or accumulated skills and experiences such as resilience, coping skills, and personality

Knox's Proficiency Theory

- A model representation of the theory contains the following interactive components: (a) the general environment, (b) past and current characteristics, (c) performance, (d) aspiration, (e) self, (f) discrepancies, (g) specific environments, (h) learning activity, and (i) teacher's role.

In this model, all components interact with each other.

Problems with Knox's Proficiency Theory

- This theory is not well known to adult educators.
- Emphasis on performance appears to limit application to learning that can be demonstrated by better performance
- How does the interaction of the mix of learning, teaching, and motivation explain learning?

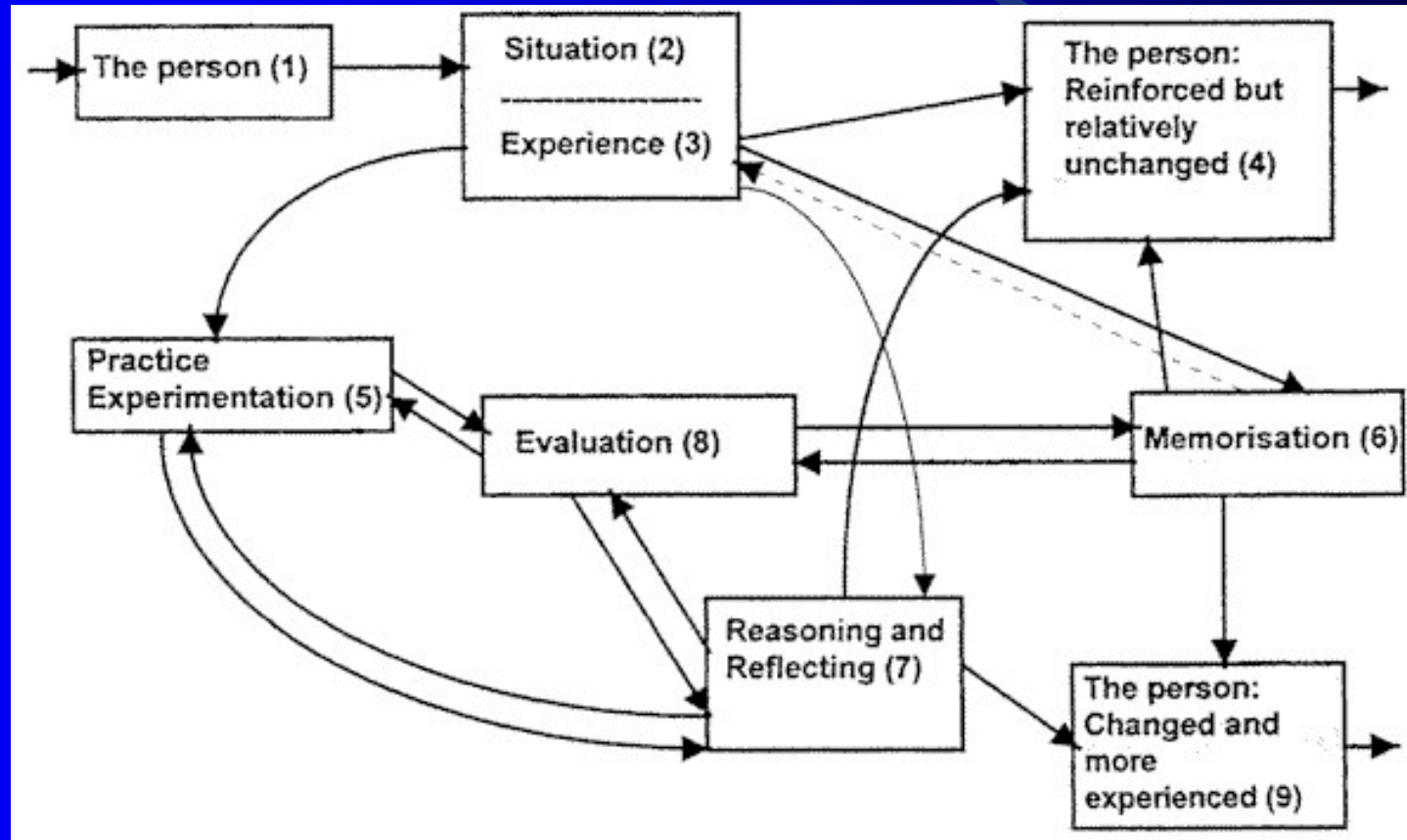
Jarvis's Learning Process

- All learning begins with experience, but lots of experience is routine, so the key is that the learning process starts when an experience calls for a response.

Jarvis's Learning Process - Strengths

- Deals with the learning process itself more than other models.
- Concentrates on explaining the responses to an experience
- These responses include many types of learning and their outcomes
- Situated in a social context
- Learning is interactive
- Constructed from research with adult learners
- Has been used in various settings

Jarvis's Learning Process Model



reproduced from Jarvis 1994

Summary

- The theories or models described in this presentation have not been fully developed and empirically tested, but each is a good practice to understand how adult learning works.

Where to Get More Information

- Merriam, S. B., and Caffarella, R. S. Learning in Adulthood. San Francisco: Jossey-Bass, 1991.
- <http://home.twcny.rr.com/hiemstra/ndacesm.html>
- <http://www-distance.syr.edu/margin.html>